

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN TOGO

Complete Community Opposition How-To

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Community action shapes what happens to the coast, land, and water of Togo — and here the threat has an unusual character, because some of the most destructive harms are not single projects but slow disasters set in motion by infrastructure elsewhere, and there is no landmark community victory to point to. Togo is a narrow West African coastal state, ruled by one family since 1967, where the sea is devouring the shore at five to ten metres a year: the former capital, Aného, and dozens of fishing villages, along with the coastal road, are projected to vanish by 2038 if nothing changes, the coast road has already been moved inland three times, and six fishing villages have simply disappeared beneath the waves. The coast road has already been moved inland three separate times, and six fishing villages have simply disappeared beneath the waves for good. This erosion is driven not by nature alone but by human works — the great dam upstream in Ghana that traps the sand the coast needs, the great dam far upstream in Ghana that traps the sand the coast needs, and the ports of Lomé and Cotonou whose structures block the drift of sediment along the shore. The drift of sand and sediment along the shore that the coast depends on to renew itself. Alongside this, a state phosphate plant on the coast at Kpémé discharges its waste into the sea, a state-run phosphate plant on the coast at Kpémé discharges its industrial waste directly into the sea, and poverty pushes fishermen to mine the very sand that protects them. This guide will be honest that Togo is a hard place to oppose the powerful, that protest has been repressed, and that no community has won a landmark victory; but it will show that the levers here, though constrained, are real.

The Togolese story teaches two things about opposing destructive projects here, and this guide states both plainly. The first is the pattern that runs through every guide: not a single silver bullet, but the combination of every lever — the affected community, the evidence, the coalition, and the pressure on the deciders — pressed together. The second is distinctly Togolese, and it is what gives this guide its real, if bounded, force. **In a semi-authoritarian state whose harms are often transboundary and infrastructural, a community has more than one arena: a constrained but real domestic space of civil society, press, and courts; a regional court that citizens can petition directly and that has ruled against the government; the regional and international programmes that fund coastal protection; and the community's own power to adapt and to demand action.** That combination — the domestic space, the regional ECOWAS Court of Justice, the international coastal programmes, and community adaptation — is the distinctive lever here, and this guide is built around it, because Togo's harms cross borders and involve foreign works, and so its remedies reach across borders too.

But the same story carries honest qualifications this guide states plainly and takes seriously. **The obstacles here are real: a semi-authoritarian government, a slow disaster hard to reverse, and an economy that leans on the very phosphate that pollutes.** Togo is ruled by a long-entrenched family; protest and opposition have been met with repression, and open confrontation carries risk. The coastal erosion is driven partly by works in another country and by decades of coastal development, and cannot simply be switched off; phosphate has long been a mainstay of the economy, so the state is slow to curb it. This guide does not pretend the community holds all the cards, or that the harms are easily undone. What it shows is how, in a constrained but not fully closed state, a community can use its real domestic space, the regional court, the

international coastal programmes, and its own adaptive power to defend its coast, its land, and its health.

Most communities do not know HOW to use the several arenas their unusual situation offers. They see the sea take their homes, the phosphate foul their water, the sand vanish from their beaches, and either flee or protest in ways that invite repression — and rarely bring the matter to the courts, the regional court, the international coastal programmes, or the community-adaptation projects that could actually help. They generate private suffering without organised, effective action across the arenas open to them. The gap between the coast defended and the coast lost is here often a gap of method — the method of using the domestic space, the regional court, the international programmes, and community adaptation together.

This guide shows what can actually be tried — inside the Togolese reality as it is, which is constrained but not without openings. It is written for the person who sees the sea eating their village, the phosphate fouling their shore, or their land taken, and who wants to know what can be done in a semi-authoritarian state facing a transboundary slow disaster. The answer is a qualified yes: the levers are real — the domestic space, the regional court, the international programmes, community adaptation — with the honest qualifiers that the government is repressive, the erosion is hard to reverse, the phosphate is economically entrenched, and there is no landmark victory to promise, only real if constrained arenas in which to act, and the need to act with care. A note on who this guide is for, and on the spirit in which it should be used. It is for the person willing to work patiently and carefully across several arenas — documenting the harm, seeking funded protection, litigating where the law can act, petitioning the regional court where rights are violated, and restoring the coast with their own hands — rather than confronting an entrenched state head-on. That is not a lesser or more timid form of action but, in Togo's constrained conditions, the most effective and the safest one, because here the levers that genuinely deliver are the funded, the legal, the regional, and the adaptive, not the confrontational. Anyone hoping to defeat the government through protest should understand that protest here has been repressed, and that the real, reachable defence of the coast runs through the funders, the regional court, and the community's own restoration. This guide is an honest map of that patient, multi-arena, and largely safer path — the path of defending and rebuilding the coast rather than confronting the state that will not defend it.

The Strategic Framework

Effective efforts follow the same underlying pattern, whether the goal is to secure coastal protection, curb phosphate pollution, or defend land:

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STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION (find the harm, the cause, and the deciders)
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STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION (build the evidence -- harm and cause)
|
STEP 3: LOCAL OPPOSITION (build the community and the coalition, carefully)
|
STEP 4: LEGAL, REGULATORY & REGIONAL (courts, ECOWAS Court, programmes)
|
STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY (make it a national and regional cause)
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These steps operate **simultaneously, not in sequence**. The evidence of harm and its cause feeds the courts, the regional court, the international programmes, and the media at once; the community organises, with care; a court case, a regional-court petition, or an approach to a coastal programme is both pressure and a spur to the next. The community that runs all five together, each reinforcing the others, gives itself the best — if still constrained — chance of defending its coast, land, and health.

The Levers That Are Distinctly Strong Here

Every country's system has its own pressure points. Togo's — a constrained but real domestic space, a transboundary harm, a regional court, and international coastal programmes — give communities a distinctive set:

- **The domestic space.** A **constrained but real civil society, press, and courts** offer genuine, if limited, arenas for a community to organise, document, and litigate.
- **The regional ECOWAS Court.** The **ECOWAS Court of Justice**, which citizens can petition directly and which has ruled against Togo, is a distinctive regional lever the government cannot control.
- **The international coastal programmes.** The **World Bank, regional, and UN coastal and climate programmes** fund protection and adaptation, and bring standards and attention.
- **The transboundary dimension.** The **regional and cross-border cause of the harm** opens regional cooperation and pressure as a lever.
- **Community adaptation.** The **community's own power to adapt** — restoring mangroves, protecting the shore, building livelihoods — is a real and fundable lever.

What This Guide Will Not Pretend

It would be dishonest to promise these levers prevail, or that the harms are easily reversed. There is **no landmark win**; the government is **semi-authoritarian** and represses protest; the erosion is a **slow, partly transboundary disaster**; and the phosphate is **economically entrenched**. This guide takes those limits seriously — it states them plainly, and it counsels care where protest is dangerous — and shows how to use the real, distinctive tools this situation offers — the domestic space, the regional court, the international programmes, and community adaptation — to defend the coast, land, and health, honestly acknowledging the repression, the transboundary difficulty, and the absence of a landmark victory.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

You cannot pull a lever you cannot see — and here you must also see where the harm truly comes from, since some of it originates beyond Togo's borders. Before you spend a single week, map who and what actually cause the harm, at which level, and where the leverage is real and the risk manageable. And map where the domestic space, the regional court, the international programmes, and community adaptation apply, because in Togo a destructive harm is best met not by dangerous confrontation alone, but by using the several arenas open to a community — the courts and civil society at home, the regional court that citizens can petition, the international coastal programmes, and the community's own adaptive power.

The Levels of Decision and Cause

A Togolese harm runs through several levels, some inside the country and some beyond it, and each is a place to intervene.

The government and the state company. The **government and the state phosphate company** make and permit the projects — the phosphate plant, the coastal works, the land allocations — and, though semi-authoritarian, are answerable to the courts, the regional court, and international partners.

The transboundary and infrastructural cause. Much of the erosion is caused by **works beyond the immediate control of the affected community** — the dam upstream in another country, the ports whose structures block the sediment — which points the remedy toward regional cooperation and coastal engineering, not only local action.

The domestic courts and civil society. A **constrained but real domestic space** — the courts, civil society, the press — offers genuine, if limited, arenas to document, organise, and litigate.

The regional ECOWAS Court. The **ECOWAS Court of Justice** can be petitioned directly by citizens over rights violations, and has ruled against Togo — a distinctive regional lever beyond the government's control.

The international programmes and partners. The **World Bank, UN, and regional coastal and climate programmes** fund protection and adaptation and bring standards and attention, and are a genuine arena of leverage.

The Journey of a Harm

A Togolese harm — the advancing sea, the phosphate discharge, a land taking — arises from a project, an infrastructure, or a slow process, and moves toward the loss of homes, health, or land, with the **community's evidence, the domestic space, the regional court, the international programmes, and community adaptation** able to intervene. **The domestic space and the international coastal programmes are where protection and remedy are pursued, and the regional court is where rights are vindicated** — and using them together is the distinctive Togolese approach. The distinctive levers are the **domestic space, the regional court, the international programmes, the transboundary cooperation, and community adaptation**. Find out exactly where the harm and its cause lie, and, crucially, **what would be lost, what causes it, and how the courts, the regional court, the programmes, and community adaptation can be engaged**, because those are where a harm can genuinely be met.

Follow the Harm, the Coast, and the Deciders

Behind a harm stand the state, a state company, an infrastructure, or a transboundary cause. Trace who and what cause it, who benefits, and — importantly here — **what coast, land, health, or livelihood would be lost, what causes the harm, at home or across the border, how the domestic and regional courts can be engaged, and how the international coastal programmes and community adaptation can help**. Two questions unlock most Togolese efforts: **What would be lost, and what causes it?** and **Which arena — the domestic space, the regional court, the international programmes, community adaptation — can address it?** The domestic space, the regional court, and the international programmes are, together, the heart of most such efforts here. Everything else in a Togolese effort ultimately serves these: the documentation exists to persuade a funder, a court, and the regional court; the community organising exists to do the adapting and to press the arenas; and the media exists to draw the funders and the region to the cause. Keep the domestic space, the regional court, and the international programmes — and the community's own adaptation — at the centre of every submission, filing, and campaign, and the effort retains a clear, multi-arena spine suited to a harm that crosses borders and a state that resists confrontation.

The Overseers

Finally, know the bodies and forces that shape a harm, because they are the community's levers. The **government and the state company; the domestic courts, civil society, and press; the ECOWAS Court of Justice; the World Bank, UN, and regional coastal and climate programmes; the regional bodies and neighbouring states** implicated in the transboundary cause; and the **community and its adaptive projects**. In Togo, the **domestic space, the regional court, the international programmes, and community adaptation** are the most distinctive levers. Each is a separate arena, and a harm whose loss and cause are documented, met through the courts, the regional court, the international programmes, and community adaptation, can genuinely be reduced, protected against, or remedied — though, honestly, the government is repressive, the erosion is a slow transboundary disaster, and the phosphate is entrenched,

and this guide will keep saying so, and keep counselling care.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Before you commit effort, calibrate honestly — and here that means acknowledging that a landmark victory is unlikely, that protest can be dangerous, and that the strongest levers work slowly across several arenas. These figures are **directional, not guarantees** — patterns drawn from how harms of this kind tend to go in Togo and comparable states, not a controlled study. The decisive variables are whether the community can **document the harm and its cause**, whether it can **use the domestic space, the regional court, and the international programmes**, and whether it can **organise safely and adapt**. Where the harm is provable and the arenas are used together, the levers here are real; but temper every figure with the honest knowledge that the government is semi-authoritarian, protest is repressed, the erosion is a slow transboundary disaster, and the phosphate is economically entrenched.

Individual Step Success Rates

Approach	Success Rate	Timeline	Cost	What "Success" Means
Documentation only	10–20%	weeks	low	Basis for every other step
Harm-and-cause case	35–55%	weeks–months	low	The loss and its cause, established
Domestic space (civil society, courts)	30–50%	months–years	low–moderate	Organising, litigation, a measure pressed
The ECOWAS Court	30–50%	months–years	low–moderate	A rights violation vindicated regionally
International coastal programmes	40–60%	months–years	low	Protection and adaptation funded
Community adaptation	45–65%	months–years	low–moderate	Mangroves, shore, livelihoods restored
All arenas together	40–60%	months–years	moderate	Protected, remedied, or adapted
Confronting the state directly	15–35%	—	risk	Repression; limited gain

Key insight: every step together beats any single one, and Togo's real strengths are the several arenas: the **domestic space**, the **regional court**, the **international programmes**, and **community adaptation**. Its constraints are specific and honest: the government is **semi-authoritarian** and represses protest, the erosion is a **slow transboundary disaster**, and the phosphate is **economically entrenched** — so progress comes through the courts, the regional court, the programmes, and adaptation, not through dangerous confrontation.

*A note on cost: the levers here — a court case, a regional-court petition, an approach to a coastal programme, a community-adaptation project — cost mainly organisation and knowledge, though litigation may need a lawyer and adaptation needs funding, which the international programmes can supply. The scarce resources are **organisation, legal help, and access to the coastal-programme funding** — much of it available through the regional and international partners. This shapes where a Togolese effort should concentrate its energy. Because the decisive resources are organisation, legal assistance, and access to coastal-programme funding — rather than the mass mobilisation that confrontation would require, or the sheer numbers that an open democracy's politics would reward — a community's most valuable early*

investments are in documenting its harm rigorously enough to persuade a funder, in finding the legal help to reach the courts and the regional court, and in connecting to the international coastal and climate programmes that hold the money protection requires. A small, well-organised community that can produce a credible case and connect it to a funder can accomplish far more, and far more safely, than a large one that pours its energy into protest. The resources that matter most are thus largely a matter of knowledge, documentation, and the right connections — all of which are within a determined community's reach, and none of which require the dangerous confrontation the state is quick to repress. And because poverty drives some harm, like the sand mining that worsens erosion, part of the real work is building the livelihoods that make protection possible.

Effectiveness Visualization

SUCCESS PROBABILITY (harm reduced, protection secured, or remedy won)

PROVABLE HARM + ARENAS USED TOGETHER + COMMUNITY ADAPTATION:

Community adaptation: 45-65%

Community adaptation: ██████████ 45-65%

International programmes: ████████ 40-60%

All arenas together:  40-60%

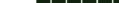
All arenas together: 40-50%

Harm-and-cause case: 35-55%

Single arena: 10-65%

CONFRONTING THE STATE DIRECTLY -- risky, limited:

Direct confrontation: ■■■■■■ 15-35% and risky

Funded protection secured:  often achievable

Mitigation / partial gain: ████████████████████ often achievable

The record / the case made: ■■■■■■■■■■■■ more reliable than a stop

How to read this honestly. The levers that most change outcomes in Togo are **community adaptation, the international coastal programmes, the domestic space, and the regional court** — used together, and pursued with care. The international coastal programmes and community adaptation show the ceiling: funded protection and community-led restoration can genuinely defend and rebuild a threatened coast. The repression of protest and the entrenchment of the phosphate economy show the honest floor: the state will resist direct challenge and will not easily curb its mainstays. Most Togolese efforts will sit between, and the honest lesson is that the levers here are real — able to secure protection, fund adaptation, vindicate rights at the regional court, and reduce harm — but that a landmark stop is unlikely, confrontation is risky, and progress comes through the several arenas together.

Step Importance Ranking (When All Combined)

1. **Community adaptation and the international programmes** — Togo's most reliable levers; funded, community-led protection and restoration.
2. **The domestic space** — the constrained but real civil society, press, and courts.
3. **The ECOWAS Court of Justice** — the distinctive regional lever for rights the government violates.
4. **The harm-and-cause case** — the provable loss and its often transboundary cause.
5. **The transboundary cooperation** — the regional dimension of a cross-border harm.

What These Campaigns Actually Show

A few honest patterns recur. **Adaptation works** — community-led mangrove restoration, shore protection, and livelihoods genuinely defend the coast. **The programmes fund it** — international and regional coastal programmes bring the money and standards protection needs. **The regional court reaches where the domestic system fails** — the ECOWAS Court has ruled against Togo on rights. **The cause is often transboundary** — the erosion is driven partly by works abroad, so remedies are regional. **But the state**

resists confrontation — protest is repressed and the phosphate is entrenched. The through-line: **document the harm and its cause; use the domestic space, the regional court, and the international programmes; build community adaptation and livelihoods; and act with care where confrontation is dangerous** — because a community that does can genuinely defend and rebuild its coast and vindicate its rights, while being honest that the government is repressive, the erosion is a slow transboundary disaster, and there is no landmark victory yet.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Every effective effort begins by finding the exact harm and its cause — and the leverage the community holds across its several arenas. Vague concern goes nowhere, and dangerous confrontation invites repression; an effort aimed at "the erosion devouring this village, caused by the port and the upstream dam, which the coastal programmes could fund protection against, the regional court could address as a rights matter, and the community could help adapt to" is a real, workable effort — the kind Togo's arenas can deliver. Answer five questions.

The Five Core Questions

- 1. What would be lost?** This is the first question here. What **coast, land, health, or livelihood** would the harm destroy — the village to the sea, the shore to phosphate, the beach to sand mining.
- 2. What causes it — at home or across the border?** What **cause** drives the harm — the phosphate plant, the port, the upstream dam, the sand mining — since the cause, often transboundary, determines the remedy.
- 3. Which coastal programmes and funding apply?** Which **international, regional, and national coastal and climate programmes** could fund protection and adaptation, the most reliable lever here.
- 4. Which courts and the regional court apply?** How the **domestic courts** and the **ECOWAS Court of Justice** can address the harm or the rights it violates.
- 5. How can the community adapt and act safely?** How the **community can adapt** — mangroves, shore protection, livelihoods — and organise **safely**, given the risk of repression.

A Worked Example

Suppose the sea is devouring a fishing village, its cause the upstream dam and the port, worsened by sand mining, and the government slow to act.

Working the five questions: **what would be lost? What causes it? Which coastal programmes apply? Which courts and the regional court apply?** And how can the community adapt and act safely? The deciders and causes are the government, the state company, the port, the upstream works, and the transboundary process, with the coastal programmes, the courts, the regional court, and community adaptation as the levers.

Within a season the effort has moved from "the sea takes our homes and nothing can be done" to a real effort: document the harm and its cause; seek coastal-programme funding for protection; build community adaptation; use the courts and the regional court for rights and remedies; and address the sand mining with livelihoods. That is a workable effort suited to Togo — one that meets a transboundary slow disaster across the arenas open to the community. Notice what the five questions accomplish, and how they suit a harm of this unusual character: they separate the harm from its cause, and the cause from its remedy, so that a

community facing something as overwhelming as a coast disappearing into the sea can break it into parts it can actually act on. The harm becomes documentable loss; the cause becomes a specific, traceable process, at home or across the border; the remedy becomes a fundable protection or adaptation; the arenas become specific funders, courts, and programmes to approach; and the safety question keeps the whole effort from tipping into the confrontation that would invite repression. That translation — from an overwhelming, seemingly unstoppable disaster into a set of specific, answerable, and largely safe tasks, each matched to an arena that can address it — is the first and most important thing a Togolese effort does, because it converts despair before a vanishing coast into a workable programme of documentation, funding, litigation, and restoration.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Documentation is the foundation everything else stands on — and here, where the case must persuade coastal programmes, courts, the regional court, and the public, sound evidence of both the harm and its cause is decisive. A programme funder, a judge, a regional-court panel, and a journalist all move on evidence — and in Togo, a clear record of the loss, its often transboundary cause, and the remedy that could meet it is precisely what an effort turns into a real result, so build it well. Build your file in three layers.

Layer 1: The Harm, the Cause, and the Deciders

Get the facts the case turns on. Identify the **harm, its location, and its cause** — the erosion and the works that drive it, the phosphate plant and its discharge, the land taking — and, crucially here, whether the cause is **domestic or transboundary**, since that determines the remedy and the arena. Establish the deciders and the cause precisely, because in Togo the remedy for a transboundary, infrastructural harm is different from the remedy for a local project, and knowing the cause is knowing where to press.

Layer 2: The Loss — to Coast, Health, and Livelihood

Document what would be lost. Establish the **environmental and physical harm** — the shoreline lost, the homes and villages taken by the sea, the phosphate pollution of water and health, the beaches stripped by sand mining. And establish the **human harm** — the displaced families, the lost fisheries and farmland, the ruined livelihoods. Draw on **the coastal and scientific studies, the international programmes' assessments, and local knowledge**, much of which exists for a coast as studied as Togo's. Photographs, coastal surveys, and testimony make the loss undeniable — and fundable.

Layer 3: The Loss, the Cause, the Remedy, and the Arena

Finally, document the case. Does the **environmental and human harm** show a real loss? What **cause**, domestic or transboundary, drives it? What **remedy** — coastal protection, pollution control, adaptation, livelihoods — could meet it, and which **arena** — the coastal programmes, the courts, the regional court, community adaptation — is open? And, where relevant, **is poverty a driver**, requiring livelihoods as part of the answer? Each is a separate element, and together they make a case that can be pressed across the arenas open to a Togolese community. This is the layer that most often decides these efforts, because a documented loss, an identified cause, a fundable remedy, and an open arena are exactly what let a Togolese community defend its coast and health. Build it well, and the coastal programmes, the courts, the regional court, and community adaptation become the community's genuine strength. One practical note on building this layer: identifying the cause precisely is more important in Togo than in almost any other country in this series, because the cause here so often determines the arena. A harm caused by a purely domestic

project — a discharge from the phosphate plant, say — points toward the domestic courts and the state's own regulators. A harm caused by works across the border — the dam upstream in Ghana that starves the coast of sediment — points instead toward regional cooperation and the transboundary frameworks, because no Togolese court can order a change to a Ghanaian dam. And a harm that is really a failure of the state to protect its own people — the government's inaction as the sea takes village after village — may point toward the regional court as a rights matter, or toward the international programmes for the protection the state has failed to provide. So the file must trace the causal chain carefully, because a community that misdiagnoses the cause will press the wrong arena and waste its effort, while one that identifies the cause precisely knows exactly which of its several arenas can actually deliver a remedy.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Evidence in hand beats evidence you assume exists. Here is where the material tends to live in a Togolese effort, and how to get it — with the **harm**, the **cause**, the **remedy**, and the **arenas** at the center, and with care for safety where confrontation is risky. Treat this as a checklist to work through, not a menu to admire.

The Harm and Cause Record

Start with the harm itself. **Coastal surveys, erosion studies, pollution measurements, and displacement records** establish what is being lost and how fast; much of this exists in the international programmes' assessments and the scientific literature on Togo's coast, and is reachable. Establish the **cause** — the upstream dam, the ports, the phosphate discharge, the sand mining — since the cause, often transboundary, determines the arena. Establish exactly **what is lost, how fast, and what causes it**, because the cause is the key to the remedy.

The Coastal, Environmental, and Health Evidence

This is the heart of the file. Gather the **environmental evidence** — the rate of erosion, the villages and coast lost, the phosphate pollution of sea and shore, the sand mining's damage — drawing on **coastal and oceanographic studies, the international programmes' data, and pollution measurements**. And gather the **health and livelihood evidence** — the illnesses linked to the phosphate discharge, the fisheries and farmland lost, the displaced families. Photographs, surveys, and testimony make the harm vivid and credible. On a coast so studied and so visibly changing, this evidence is powerful and often already gathered.

The Remedy and Programme Record

Document the remedy and the funding, because these are the distinctive Togolese levers. Establish what **coastal protection** — breakwaters, groynes, nourishment, mangrove restoration — could defend the shore; what **pollution control** could curb the phosphate discharge; what **adaptation and livelihoods** could rebuild. And identify the **coastal and climate programmes** — the World Bank's regional coastal programme, the UN and regional climate funds, the national coastal plans — that could fund them, since funded remedy is the most reliable path here. A community that can show a fundable remedy to a documented harm holds the strongest card in Togo.

The Legal and Regional Record

Document the legal and regional levers. Gather the **domestic environmental and land law** and how the harm may breach it; the basis for a **regional court petition** where rights — to health, to home, to a healthy environment — are violated, noting that the ECOWAS Court has ruled against Togo before; and the

transboundary and regional frameworks relevant to a cross-border harm like the sediment-trapping dam. A community that can frame its harm as a rights violation for the regional court, or a transboundary matter for regional cooperation, holds levers beyond the government's control.

The People and the Community

Finally, map the human terrain, with care for safety. Who is affected — the coastal villages, the fishers, the farmers, those poisoned by the phosphate? Who are the allies — the **domestic civil society and environmental groups, the international programmes, the regional bodies, the sympathetic experts, the diaspora**? And how can the community **organise and adapt safely**, given the risk of repression? A Togolese effort is advanced through the community and its allies, using the several arenas with care — so map that coalition and those arenas deliberately, and mind the safety of those who organise.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

Evidence does not move deciders by itself. A community — organised, informed, and adapting — is what turns evidence into action, across the several arenas open to a Togolese community, and with care where confrontation is dangerous. And here, distinctively, the community's own power to adapt is itself a lever: restoring mangroves, protecting the shore, and building livelihoods are not merely coping but a genuine, fundable defence of the coast.

Why the Community Is Decisive

In Togo, an organised community is decisive across every arena — but it must organise with care, because open confrontation with the state invites repression. The community supplies what an effort runs on: the affected voices, the local knowledge, the legitimacy, and — distinctively here — the hands that do the adapting, restoring the mangroves and protecting the shore. When a community organises to document, to seek funding, to litigate, and to adapt, it becomes a genuine force across the arenas open to it. **A united community here is not merely the backdrop; it is the documenter, the litigant, the fundable partner, and the adapter — the engine of a Togolese effort, provided it acts with due care.** This last role — the adapter — is genuinely distinctive to the Togolese situation and worth dwelling on, because it changes what "opposition" even means here. In many countries a community's task is to stop a project by pressing the deciders; in Togo, where the greatest harm is a slow, partly transboundary disaster that no local decider fully controls, a community's most powerful action is often not to stop something but to defend and rebuild directly — planting the mangroves that hold the shore, restoring the wetlands that buffer the sea, building the sea defences and the livelihoods that let people stay. This adaptive work is not a consolation prize for failing to stop the harm; it is, for a coast being eaten by the sea, frequently the most effective defence available, and it has the great virtue of being both fundable by the international programmes and far safer than confronting an entrenched state. A community that understands this reorients its energy toward the adaptation it can actually accomplish, and finds in that work both real protection and a form of opposition the state has no reason to repress.

Finding the Affected Community

Begin with those the harm touches most — the **coastal villagers losing homes to the sea, the fishers, the farmers, those whose health the phosphate harms** — whose stake is direct and grave. Widen to all who depend on the coast and its fisheries, which in a coastal nation is many. Name the shared stake — **our coast, our homes, our fisheries, our health, our children's ground** — because in a country where villages are vanishing into the sea, the defence of the coast is a matter of survival that unites. There is a

particular power in framing the cause around the coast's slow disappearance, because it is a harm that touches an entire stretch of shore at once and binds many communities in a common fate. The sea does not take one village's beach and spare the next; the erosion that swallows one fishing settlement threatens all of them along the drift, and the phosphate that fouls one shore drifts to the others. This shared exposure means that the affected are not a single village to be isolated and ignored but a whole coastal population with a common stake, and an effort that frames itself around that shared fate — the defence of a coast on which many communities and the nation's fisheries depend — can draw together a breadth of support that a single-village grievance never could. On a vanishing coast, the widest possible framing is also the truest.

Coalition-Building, With Care

A community allied is stronger than a community alone, and in Togo the coalition spans the arenas. Reach to the **domestic environmental and civil-society groups**; the **international coastal and climate programmes** that fund adaptation; the **regional bodies and legal networks** that can support a regional-court petition; the **sympathetic experts** on erosion and pollution; and the **diaspora**. Frame the coalition around the shared defence of a disappearing coast and a poisoned shore, and around fundable adaptation. Build breadth with care, mindful that some forms of organising are safer than others in a semi-authoritarian state — favour the documentary, the legal, the funded, and the adaptive over the confrontational.

Sustaining the Effort

Togolese efforts can be sustained through the community's own adaptive work and the arenas' slow processes. Keep the community **informed, organised, and adapting**; mark real steps — a coastal-protection project funded, a mangrove restored, a court case filed, a regional-court petition lodged, a livelihood built. And keep the effort grounded in adaptation and the funded arenas, which are both effective and safer than confrontation, and address the poverty — like that behind the sand mining — that drives some harm. The effort that lasts is the one that stays organised and adapting, uses the several arenas with care, and builds the livelihoods that make protection possible. Sustaining such an effort is helped, in Togo, by the tangible and ongoing nature of adaptation, which gives a community visible, renewable proof that its work matters — a stretch of mangroves growing back, a shore held against a season's storms, a cooperative earning a living from restored lagoons. These concrete gains renew a community's energy in a way that the slow, uncertain arenas of litigation and funding cannot, and they continue to protect the coast regardless of the politics above. The discipline is to keep the adaptive work going as the anchor of the effort, while the slower legal, regional, and funding arenas advance alongside it — so that the community always has, in its own restored coast, a living proof that its labour is defending the ground beneath its feet.

STEP 4: LEGAL, REGULATORY & REGIONAL CHALLENGES — THE COURTS, THE ECOWAS COURT OF JUSTICE, AND THE REGIONAL PROGRAMMES

This is where a Togolese effort is realistically advanced — not through dangerous confrontation, but through the **domestic courts, the regional ECOWAS Court of Justice, and the regional and international programmes** that a semi-authoritarian but not fully closed state answers to. Here the legal, regional, and programmatic levers come together, because in Togo a community's constrained domestic space, the regional court beyond the government's control, and the international programmes are, together, how the coast and health are defended.

Setting Expectations Honestly

First, the honest truth. The levers are **real but bounded**. The domestic courts are **constrained** by a semi-authoritarian state, yet not wholly closed; the regional court is **genuine and beyond the government's control**, but slow and limited to rights matters; and the international programmes are **real and fundable**, but work at the pace of projects, not politics. What these levers realistically achieve is **coastal protection funded, pollution mitigated, adaptation built, a rights violation vindicated regionally, and land defended** — real outcomes, if not a dramatic single stop. Enter this front clear-eyed and careful: the courts, the regional court, and the programmes are Togo's distinctive levers, strongest when the **harm is provable and a remedy is fundable** — but the state is repressive, so favour the legal, regional, and funded over the confrontational.

The Domestic Space and Courts

The first front is the constrained domestic space. Togo's **civil society, press, and courts**, though limited by a semi-authoritarian state, are not wholly closed, and offer genuine arenas. Use the **domestic courts** to challenge a pollution, a land taking, or a failure to protect where the law allows; use **civil society and the press** to document and organise, with care. This domestic space is real, if bounded, and a community that uses it skilfully — favouring litigation and documentation over dangerous confrontation — can press its case at home.

The ECOWAS Court of Justice

The second and distinctive front is the regional court. The **ECOWAS Court of Justice** can be petitioned directly by citizens and NGOs over violations of their rights — including the rights to health, to home, and to a healthy environment — and, crucially, it lies beyond the Togolese government's control, and has ruled against Togo before. Where a harm — the phosphate poisoning, the failure to protect a vanishing coast, a repression of those who protest — amounts to a rights violation, the regional court is a genuine and distinctive arena, reachable directly and answerable to no domestic power. Frame the harm as a rights violation, gather the evidence, and, with legal help, petition the regional court — a lever few of the harder countries in this series possess.

The Regional and International Programmes

The third front is the programmes and the transboundary cause. The **World Bank's regional coastal programme, the UN and regional climate funds, and the national coastal plans** can fund the protection and adaptation the coast needs, and are the most reliable path to real defence. And because the erosion is partly **transboundary** — driven by the dam upstream and the regional ports — the **regional bodies and neighbouring states** are an arena for cooperation on the shared cause. Engage the programmes for funding and the regional bodies for the cross-border cause, because a harm that crosses borders is met by remedies that cross borders too. The transboundary character of Togo's coastal erosion is worth understanding fully, because it is both the harm's deepest cause and, counterintuitively, an opening. The coast is starved of sand partly because a great dam upstream in a neighbouring country holds back the sediment the shore once received, and partly because the region's ports interrupt the natural drift of sand along the coast; the same forces erode the shores of Togo's neighbours too. This means no Togolese community, and indeed no Togolese government, can solve the problem alone — but it also means the problem is a shared regional one, in which neighbouring states and communities have a common interest and regional bodies have a genuine role. Framing the erosion as a regional crisis requiring regional cooperation on sediment management and coastal protection, rather than as a purely national failure, both

diagnoses it truthfully and opens the door to the regional partnerships and the international climate finance that a shared, cross-border crisis can attract. The transboundary cause, honestly named, is also a transboundary opportunity. Pursued together — the domestic space, the regional court, the programmes, and regional cooperation — these fronts are how a Togolese community defends its coast and health within a constrained but not closed state. It is worth understanding why these fronts complement one another so well in Togo's particular situation. The domestic courts and civil society supply the arena closest to home, useful for the harms the domestic law can reach, but constrained by a semi-authoritarian state that limits how far they can go. The regional court supplies exactly what the domestic space lacks — independence from the government — and so is the arena of choice for the rights violations a captured domestic system will not remedy. And the international programmes supply what neither court can: the money and the engineering to actually protect and rebuild a coast, which is, in the end, what a community losing its shore most needs. Each covers the others' weaknesses: the domestic space where the law can act, the regional court where the government cannot be trusted, the programmes where funding and physical protection are required. A community that grasps this division of labour — litigating at home where it can, at the regional court where it must, and building funded protection throughout — uses each arena for what it does best, and so makes the most of a constrained but genuinely multi-arena situation.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Evidence does not speak for itself; you must aim it at each decider in the language that moves them. The same file of harm, cause, and remedy becomes different arguments for a coastal programme, a court, the regional court, and the public. Translate deliberately, and with care.

For the Coastal Programmes and Funders

The programmes respond to **a fundable, well-documented need and a workable remedy**. Frame the harm as a clear case for coastal protection or adaptation: here is the erosion and its cause, here is the protection or restoration that would meet it, here is the community ready to partner. Give them the evidence, the remedy, and the community's readiness, so funding a defence of the coast becomes an obvious, deliverable project. This is the argument that most reliably brings real protection here. It is worth emphasising that the coastal programmes are, of all the levers in this guide, the one most likely to deliver tangible, physical protection to a Togolese community, and so deserve particular attention. Courts and regional petitions can vindicate rights and establish duties, and media can draw attention, but none of them can place a rock revetment along an eroding shore, restore a belt of mangroves, or nourish a beach with sand — and those physical works are, for a coast being eaten by the sea, what actually saves homes and livelihoods. The international and regional coastal and climate programmes exist precisely to fund such works, and they operate on a logic — of documented vulnerability, workable projects, and community partnership — that a well-prepared community can genuinely satisfy. So while every arena matters, an effort that treats the coastal programmes as its most reliable path to real protection, and invests heavily in building the documented, fundable, community-backed case those programmes require, is an effort aimed squarely at the outcome that most matters: a coast actually defended.

For the Domestic Courts

Domestic courts respond to **the law**, within the limits of a semi-authoritarian state. Frame the harm as a breach of environmental or land law, or a failure of a legal duty to protect, and seek the remedy the law allows. Give the court, through a lawyer, a clean legal case. Be realistic about the constraints, but use the domestic courts where they can genuinely act, favouring the legal over the confrontational.

For the ECOWAS Court of Justice

The regional court responds to **rights violations, and lies beyond the government's reach**. Frame the harm as a violation of rights — to health, to home, to a healthy environment — or the repression of those who defend the coast as a violation of civil rights, and, with legal help, petition the court directly. Give it the documented violation and the remedy sought. The regional court's independence from the domestic power is its great value; use it for what the domestic system cannot deliver. It is worth being clear about both the reach and the limits of this regional court, honestly. Its great value is its independence: because it sits above the national government and can be petitioned directly by citizens and organisations, it offers a forum that a captured or compromised domestic judiciary cannot, and its rulings carry real weight and international attention, as its past judgments against Togo have shown. Its limits are equally real: it is concerned with rights rather than with engineering or funding, so it can vindicate a violation and order a remedy but cannot itself build a sea wall or fund a mangrove restoration; and its processes are slow, and a determined government may drag its feet on compliance. Understanding both means using the regional court for what it does best — establishing that a harm or a repression is a rights violation the government must answer for — while relying on the international programmes and community adaptation for the physical protection that no court can supply.

For the Public, the Region, and the World

The public and the region respond to **a vivid, human, and shared story**; the world to **a striking case of climate and infrastructural injustice**. Translate the file into a story anyone can grasp: villages vanishing into the sea, a coast poisoned by phosphate, a disaster driven partly by works across the border — and a community fighting to defend and rebuild its shore. Frame it as a shared West African coastal crisis and a matter of justice. Keep it accurate; credibility is quickly tested. And mind the safety of those who speak.

The Golden Rule

Never fabricate, never exaggerate, and mind the safety of those who act. Your credibility is your greatest asset, and in a constrained state it is quickly tested. State the harm precisely, identify the cause honestly, and offer a fundable remedy. Favour the legal, regional, and funded arenas over dangerous confrontation, and protect those who organise. A community that is precise, credible, and careful — pressing its case through the arenas that work — is far harder to dismiss, and far safer, than one that overreaches or courts repression.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media and attention convert your evidence into pressure — but in Togo, the story must be told with care, mindful of a semi-authoritarian state, and aimed as much at the funders and the region as at a government that resists confrontation. The story — villages vanishing into the sea, a coast poisoned, a disaster driven partly from across the border — is one that moves a nation, a region, and the world.

Why Media Matters

The government, the funders, the region, and the world behave differently when the harm is visible. Media does three things here: it **informs and unites the affected communities**, it **draws the coastal programmes and funders** whose money protection needs, and it **frames the harm** as a shared West African crisis and a matter of justice. But media here must be careful: a story that directly attacks the entrenched government may invite repression; a story that dramatises the disaster and calls for protection, funding, and regional cooperation is both safer and more effective. Aim the story at the funders, the region,

and the world as much as at the state. This reorientation of the audience is one of the most important adjustments a Togolese media effort makes, and it flows directly from the constrained political situation. In an open democracy, media pressure works by turning public opinion against the government and forcing it to respond; in Togo, where the government is entrenched and resistant and where attacking it openly can invite repression, that mechanism is both less effective and more dangerous. But the same story that would merely anger the government can, aimed elsewhere, mobilise real help: told to the international funders, it becomes the case for a coastal-protection grant; told to the region, it becomes a call for cooperation on a shared crisis; told to the world, it becomes a compelling instance of climate and infrastructural injustice that draws attention and resources. The art is to point the story where it will summon help rather than where it will only provoke a resistant state.

Crafting Your Narrative

Lead with the vanishing coast and the human loss. The strongest frame is concrete and moving: *the sea is devouring our villages and the phosphate is poisoning our shore — a disaster driven partly by works across the border — and we are fighting to defend and rebuild our coast, and we need protection, funding, and regional action*. Put the human and coastal loss first, and the call for funded protection and regional cooperation close behind, because that call engages the funders and the region. Keep it scrupulously accurate; overstatement is quickly caught. The Togolese story is powerful because the loss is visible, dramatic, and unjust.

Choosing Your Channels

Match the channel to the audience, and to safety. **Local radio and community networks** for the affected communities; the **national and regional media** for the wider public and the region; the **international coastal, climate, and news media** for the funders and the global audience, framed as a coastal-justice story; and the **domestic press with care**, given the constraints. Because Togo's harms answer to funders, the region, and the world as much as to a resistant state, the regional and international channels matter greatly — and are often safer than confronting the government directly at home.

A Few Cautions

Stay accurate, careful, and constructive — the goal is protection, funding, and regional action, not a confrontation that invites repression. Aim the story at the funders, the region, and the world, and frame it around the shared coastal crisis and the fundable remedy, not around attacking the government. Protect those who speak, especially inside the country. Handle the government and the state company factually. And sustain the story around the visible, ongoing disaster and the community's adaptation. Above all, let the vanishing coast and the fight to defend it carry the story, because that is where a Togolese effort is strongest and safest.

EMAILS & LETTERS: TEMPLATES THAT WORK

Templates save time and prevent mistakes, but adapt every one — insert the real harm, the real cause, and the real remedy, keep it factual, and mind safety. Here a fundable remedy, and care, win.

8A: Requesting Information

Subject: Request for information — coastal harm at [location]

Dear [official / department],

I am writing on behalf of [community] regarding the [erosion / phosphate pollution / land taking] affecting [location]. To understand and respond to this harm, we request the **relevant assessments and plans**, information on the **cause and the measures considered**, and the **coastal-protection and adaptation programmes** that may apply. We wish to help protect our coast and our community.

We would be grateful for a response by [date].

Respectfully,

[Name, community, contact]

8B: Application to a Coastal or Climate Programme

Subject: Coastal protection and adaptation for [community]

Dear [World Bank / UN / climate fund / programme],

Our community at [location] faces [erosion / pollution] destroying [homes / fisheries / health], caused by [the dam / the port / the phosphate plant]. We seek partnership and funding for [coastal protection / mangrove restoration / adaptation / livelihoods], and our community is ready to lead the work. We can provide documentation of the harm and its cause, and a clear plan for the remedy. May we discuss support?

Respectfully,

[Name, community, contact]

8C: Petition to the ECOWAS Court of Justice (via counsel)

Subject: Rights violation regarding [harm] at [location]

To the [ECOWAS Court of Justice / counsel],

Our community, affected by [phosphate poisoning / the failure to protect our vanishing coast / repression of our advocacy] at [location], seeks to bring a matter concerning the violation of our rights — to health, to home, to a healthy environment — before the regional court. We have documentation of the harm and the violation, and seek legal assistance to petition the Court, which has addressed such matters concerning Togo before.

Respectfully,

[Name, community, contact]

8D: Letter to a Domestic Environmental or Civil-Society Group

Subject: Partnership to defend our coast at [location]

Dear [organisation],

Our community faces [harm] at [location], and we seek your partnership — your expertise, your documentation, and your voice — to defend our coast and health through the courts, the programmes, and community adaptation. We know the risks of confrontation and wish to act through the arenas that work. May we work together?

With respect,

[Name, community, contact]

8E: Media Pitch

Subject: A coast vanishing into the sea at [location]

Dear [journalist],

At [location], the sea is devouring [village], caused partly by [the upstream dam and the ports], while [phosphate pollution] poisons the shore — and the community is fighting to defend and rebuild it. There is a powerful coastal-justice story here — a disaster driven partly from across the border, and a community's fight — and we can provide the evidence, the cause, and community voices, told with care for safety.

Sincerely,

[Name, community, contact]

8F: Letter to a Regional Body (Transboundary Cause)

Subject: Regional cooperation on coastal erosion at [location]

Dear [ECOWAS / regional coastal body],

The erosion destroying our coast at [location] is driven partly by [the dam upstream and the regional ports], a transboundary cause that no single community or country can address alone. We respectfully urge regional cooperation on the shared coastal crisis — sediment management, coastal protection, and joint planning. We can provide documentation of the cause and the harm.

Respectfully,

[Name, community, contact]

8G: Letter Proposing Livelihoods (Sand Mining)

Subject: Protecting our coast while supporting our people

Dear [authority / programme / NGO],

Our coast at [location] suffers from [sand mining] that worsens the erosion, driven by the poverty of those who harvest it. We believe the answer combines protection with **alternative livelihoods** — aquaculture, restored fisheries, other work — as coastal programmes have supported elsewhere in Togo. We ask your help both to protect the coast and to support those who depend on it.

Respectfully,

[Name, community, contact]

8H: Rallying the Community

Subject: Our coast, our homes, our future — let us defend them

Dear neighbours,

The sea is taking our village and the phosphate is fouling our shore — but together, through the courts, the coastal programmes, the regional court, and our own work restoring the coast, we can defend and rebuild it. Please join us: come to [gathering], share what you know, and add your voice. Let us act wisely and together — documenting, seeking funding, and restoring our coast — to defend the ground our ancestors settled.

With respect,

[Name, community]

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

Sometimes a harm is moving fast — the sea breaching a village, a discharge worsening, a land taking imminent — and you cannot run the full effort. Triage to the levers that work fastest and safest here, which means an emergency appeal to a coastal programme, the documentation, and community protection.

The First 48 Hours

Establish the essentials: **what is being lost, how fast, and what causes it**. Identify the immediate pressure point — an **advancing breach, a discharge, an imminent taking** — because that is what you must affect first. Reach a **coastal or climate programme and the domestic environmental groups** at once, because in Togo funded protection and organised civil society are the fastest routes to real, and safer, action — and begin the **community's own protective work** where it can help.

The Fastest-Moving Levers

Some levers work faster than others. **An emergency appeal to a coastal programme** can mobilise protection and funding. **Documentation and the press**, told with care, can draw attention and support fast. **Community protective work** — sandbags, barriers, mangrove planting — can begin at once. **A domestic environmental group's involvement** brings expertise and standing quickly. These outpace the slower work of litigation and the regional court — which should follow — and are safer than confrontation.

Emergency Coalition-Building

You cannot build a full coalition overnight, but here you can reach the funders and the civil-society groups fast, and begin adapting. Reach immediately to the **coastal programmes, the domestic environmental groups, the sympathetic experts, and the community itself**. A community documenting the harm, appealing for funded protection, and beginning its own defence, at the moment of crisis, is the most a rapid Togolese effort can do — and among the safest. Speed favours the prepared: know the harm, the cause, the programmes, and your allies before the crisis breaks.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Here, honestly, the system is tilted by a semi-authoritarian government, an entrenched phosphate economy, and a transboundary disaster hard to reverse. This is Togo's central, honest truth, and the whole guide has been shaped by it. Name it plainly, because pretending the field is level, or that confrontation is safe, would be false and dangerous.

Recognising a Tilted Field

The signs are specific and honest. **Power is long-entrenched** — one family has ruled since 1967, and protest has been repressed. **The phosphate is a mainstay** — long a large share of the economy, so the state is slow to curb its pollution. **The harm is partly transboundary** — driven by works across the border, beyond any single actor's control. **Confrontation is risky** — open protest can invite repression. This is not a level field, and an effort here must be built to work through the funded, legal, and regional arenas rather than through dangerous confrontation.

Strategies for a Tilted Field

When the field is tilted, use the arenas that work and the leverage the state cannot control. Lean on the **international coastal programmes** that fund protection regardless of domestic politics; the **regional ECOWAS Court** beyond the government's reach; **community adaptation** that defends the coast directly; and the **regional cooperation** the transboundary cause demands. Favour the **funded, legal, and adaptive over the confrontational**, because these both work and are safer. Address the **poverty** — like that behind the sand mining — that drives some harm. And build the record and the protection even where the state resists, because a documented harm and a funded remedy accumulate into real defence over time. A tilted field here is worked not by challenging the state head-on, but by reaching the funders, the regional court, and the community's own adaptive power. This is the strategic heart of a Togolese effort, and it distinguishes it from both the fully open and the fully closed countries in this series. In an open democracy, a community can challenge the state directly through politics and protest; in a fully closed state, it can do nothing domestically at all and must work entirely from abroad. Togo sits between: the state is repressive enough that head-on confrontation is dangerous and unlikely to succeed, but not so closed that all domestic and regional arenas are shut. The winning strategy, therefore, is neither the open democracy's confrontation nor the closed state's pure exile work, but a patient, multi-arena approach that largely goes around the state — reaching the international funders who will protect the coast regardless of the government, the regional court that the government cannot control, and the community's own adaptive capacity that needs no permission — while using the constrained domestic space only where it can genuinely act. Going around the obstacle, rather than through it, is how a tilted but not closed field is worked.

The Honest Possibility of Losing

You may lose — a village may go under, a discharge may continue — and this guide will not pretend otherwise; the erosion is a slow, partly transboundary disaster, and the state is resistant. But here the work is rarely wholly wasted: the **harm was documented, protection funded where possible, adaptation built, rights pursued at the regional court, and the next effort starts stronger** — and community adaptation, once begun, keeps defending the coast whatever the politics. Fight to save this stretch of coast; if the sea takes it, the mangroves restored, the livelihoods built, the protection funded, and the precedents set will defend the next, because on a coast this threatened, the long work of adaptation is itself the victory. There is a hard consolation in this that is worth stating plainly, because it is true and because it sustains an effort through losses. On a coast where the sea advances several metres every year and the deepest causes lie partly across a border, some ground will be lost no matter how well a community fights; villages that stood for generations may still go under. But the mangroves a community plants, the sea defences it wins funding for, the livelihoods it builds, and the rights it establishes at the regional court do not vanish with the tide — they protect the next stretch of coast, and the next community, and they accumulate, over years, into a genuinely more defended shore. In this fight, more than most, the measure of success is not a single project stopped but a coast progressively defended and a people helped to endure upon it, and that measure a determined community can genuinely meet.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO IS CAPTURED

In Togo, governance and corruption are real concerns — an entrenched ruling family, an economy leaning on a state-run resource, and limited transparency create genuine risks of capture, and these must be approached with care, because raising them can be dangerous in a semi-authoritarian state, and the safer, more effective route runs through the legal, regional, and international channels.

Telling Capture from the Ordinary Tilt

An entrenched semi-authoritarian government pursuing its priorities is tilted; where public resources and revenues flow opaquely to the connected, it may also be captured. The marks of capture are sharper: **opaque revenues from the phosphate and other resources, enforcement and protection withheld from ordinary communities, contracts and allocations to the connected, and the silencing of critics.** Be rigorous and careful: **distinguish an entrenched government's ordinary conduct from provable corruption**, and do not level accusations the evidence does not support, especially where doing so is dangerous. The regional court, the international programmes' own anti-corruption rules, and international investigative and transparency bodies are the safer tools, because they can pursue through established channels what is risky to pursue at home.

Responding to Capture — Carefully

Where capture is real, the response runs through the safer, external and legal channels. Use the **international programmes' and funders' anti-corruption and transparency rules**, which bind the projects they fund. Take evidence to **regional and international investigative and transparency bodies**, which can pursue from beyond the state's reach. Use the **regional court** where capture produces rights violations. Document meticulously and protect every source, because in a constrained state the evidence is both weapon and risk. Route the exposure through the legal, regional, and international channels — not through dangerous domestic confrontation.

A Note on Safety and Care

This note governs everything here. Togo is semi-authoritarian, and protest and opposition have been repressed — so pursue this work with real care for safety. Favour the **funded, legal, regional, and adaptive arenas** over confrontation, because they both work and carry less risk. Protect those who organise and speak, especially inside the country, and never expose a community member to danger for the sake of a gesture. Rely on documentation, the coastal programmes, the regional court, and community adaptation, which advance the cause while protecting people. Care here means favouring the effective, safer arenas and protecting the community — because no stretch of coast defended is worth a person harmed, and because the real work of protection and adaptation can be done, and is being done, through the arenas that do not require dangerous confrontation.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE: RUNNING ALL FIVE STEPS TOGETHER

The steps in this guide are written in sequence but run in parallel, each feeding the others. Here is how they fit into a single, careful effort against a destructive harm in Togo.

The Parallel Effort

From the start, the five run together, with care. **Documentation** builds the harm-cause-and-remedy file. **Target identification** aims it at the arenas. **Local opposition** organises the community and begins adaptation. **Legal, regulatory, and regional** work presses the courts, the regional court, and the programmes. **Media** makes it a national, regional, and global cause. The harm, the cause, and the remedy feed all five at once — a documented harm is a case for a coastal programme, a matter for the courts, a petition for the regional court, and a story for the world together. Run in parallel, they compound; run one at a time, they stall — and here, spanning the domestic, regional, and international arenas, they compound

across borders.

A Rough Timeline

Early (weeks 1–8): establish the harm, its cause, and the remedy; identify the coastal programmes, the legal avenues, and the community's adaptive options; begin documentation and, where urgent, protective work. **Middle (months 2–18):** seek coastal-programme funding; build community adaptation; pursue the domestic courts and, where rights are violated, the regional court; and engage the regional bodies on the transboundary cause. **Later (months and years):** secure funded protection, built adaptation, and any remedies or vindications, and keep the community's adaptive work going whatever the politics. A Togolese effort is patient, and its most reliable fruits — funded protection and community adaptation — are long in coming; pace it accordingly, and act throughout with care.

The Core Discipline

Through it all, hold the discipline that gives these efforts their force: **document the harm and its cause; use the domestic space, the regional court, and the international programmes; build community adaptation and livelihoods; act with care where confrontation is dangerous; and keep every claim precise.** The community that presses all five, spanning the domestic, regional, and international arenas and defending its coast through funded protection and its own adaptation, is the one that can genuinely defend and rebuild its coast and vindicate its rights — even against a slow, transboundary disaster and a resistant state.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Opposing a destructive harm in Togo is genuinely difficult, and bound up with a semi-authoritarian government, a transboundary slow disaster, and an entrenched phosphate economy, and this guide has been honest about that from its first line: there is no landmark victory, protest is repressed, and the erosion is hard to reverse. And yet the effort is not futile, because Togo offers a community more than one arena — a constrained but real domestic space, a regional court beyond the government's control, international coastal programmes that fund protection, and the community's own power to adapt — and used together, and with care, these levers are real.

Some honest truths hold across every effort here. **Community adaptation and the international coastal programmes are the most reliable levers, funding and building real protection. The regional court reaches where the domestic system fails, and the domestic space, though constrained, is not closed. The harm is often transboundary, so its remedies are regional. But the government is repressive, the erosion is a slow disaster, and there is no landmark victory yet.** Hold both truths at once: real, distinctive, multi-arena levers, and the honest weight of repression, transboundary difficulty, and entrenchment.

Above all, keep the discipline — and the care — that give these efforts their force. Document the harm and its cause. Use the domestic space, the regional court, and the international programmes. Build community adaptation and livelihoods. Act with care where confrontation is dangerous, and protect those who organise. And keep every claim precise — because across the courts, the funders, and the region, a credible, careful community pressing its case through the arenas that work is genuinely effective, and can defend and rebuild real ground.

The sea is devouring Aného and the villages of the Togolese coast, six of them already gone beneath the waves, the road driven inland again and again, and the phosphate plant fouls the shore — a slow disaster

driven partly by a dam and ports beyond the community's reach, in a country ruled by one family for over half a century; this guide has hidden none of it, and there is no landmark victory here to promise you. But a community here is not without arenas: the international coastal programmes will fund protection, the regional court will hear rights the government violates, the domestic space, though narrow, is not closed, and the community's own hands can restore the mangroves and rebuild the shore. the community's own hands can restore the mangroves, hold the sand, and rebuild the shore. There is no easy victory, and no landmark precedent to inherit; this guide has said so throughout, and counselled care where confrontation is dangerous. There is no easy victory to be had here, and no landmark precedent of triumph to inherit; this guide has said so plainly throughout, and counselled real care wherever confrontation is dangerous. But your coast, your homes, your fisheries, and your health are worth defending, the arenas open to you are real, and the patient, careful work of documenting the harm, winning funded protection, vindicating your rights, and restoring your own coast is one your community can genuinely do the patient, careful work of documenting the harm, winning funded protection, vindicating your rights at the regional court, and restoring your own coast with your own hands is one your community can genuinely do — and rebuild real ground. So can you.